

The Human API

IN OUR INCREASINGLY CONNECTED WORLD,

we've gotten into the habit of interacting with tens of digital devices daily. Those of us in the business of covering technology news tend to interact with many more. Practically every device that we touch has some AI component that's focused on learning our habits and making it easier for their masters to better understand the user i.e., us. We humans have a knack for being unpredictable and AI helps do away with that facet of ours in more ways than one. Earlier this month, the New York Times came out with an article showcasing how anonymous data gathering APIs within smartphone apps were able to gather enough information about users making the anonymity aspect seem like a token buzz word. Some of the apps would collect data more than 14,000 times in a day and would include accurate GPS data with each collection. That's just one app, the average smartphone user has 35 apps on their phone and us Indians install about 50. They may not frequently use all 50 apps, but those installed apps aren't waiting for you. If you've fired up the app even once and follow through the initial setup process, then you've given the green signal for it to start collecting data.

One app can collect an insane amount of data and 50 apps simply redefine the meaning of insane. Moreover, they talk to each other and with the same third-party aggregators. Apps that use the same tracking framework assign a unique identifier to the individual. The identifier doesn't record your name, age or any other personally identifiable data but it might as well. Once the data gets to the aggregator service, it can build a complete profile of you without actually slapping your name onto the profile. For all intents and purposes, that information IS you. These marketing services already do a damn good job of selling stuff to YOU and selling YOU to others. The only untapped market is the real world and the marketing execs call it 'phygital world' (phygital = physical + digital) and a good amount of effort goes into ensuring that all the brick and mortar stores also get a piece of the digital action. After all, the consumers are phygital, so the sellers have to follow the consumers into this mixed-domain. Technologies such as AR have already seen

plenty of action in the marketing domain. In fact, that's one of the most common use-cases for AR technology.

We've also seen startups that use this data to help companies identify the best location to open their stores. If Nike wants to know which place in India has the highest density of college going kids who also have enough spending power and like to buy the kind of products that Nike wants to sell, they can simply approach these tracking companies and shortlist the ideal locations. In a way, this is a good thing because people who have a 'want' are being served better. However, the underside of this aspect is the emergence of a walled garden in the real world. Companies which have deep pockets and can purchase phygital marketing data, get to sell their products whereas those who don't have the money have to resort to the plain old way of marketing. Walled gardens are extremely common online and the emergence of the same in the real world needs to be addressed. Take for example, Google's new rich cards for products. These rich cards will show all the information such as specifications, pricing, e-commerce stores which sell them and user reviews, all in one place. Most users have absolutely no reason to scroll away from the rich card and thus, websites which relied on Google traffic and affiliate marketing are going to perish slowly.

The whole battle for net neutrality was just the beginning towards ensuring fairness. Similar battles will be fought and need to be fought to ensure a diverse market with plenty of options, or slowly every single market will develop into a monopoly or a duopoly over time, because that's simply how capitalism works. Don't mistake me for a commie, I am just aware of how damaging monopolies are for the consumer. Access to data about users needs to be regulated and agencies need to be proactive in enforcing privacy laws. Think of it like channeling your request for information about your user, through the human API.

Off topic: First! 



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